

DELHI | Besieged by Scandal

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Chief of Army Staff V.K. Singh is being flooded by scandals surrounding his colleagues in uniform. Barely three months into his tenure, General Singh is dealing with what must seem like an artillery barrage of bad headlines for the army. First came the "staged encounter

GENERAL SINGH
killing" of three unemployed youth by two army officers in J&K earlier this year. Next was the case of a lieutenant-general accused of molesting the wife of a junior officer on a foreign tour. This was followed by the Armed Forces Tribunal pronouncing a verdict accusing a major-general of fudging the Kargil war account in 1999 to deny a junior officer a gallantry award. Now a major is accused of espionage in the Andaman and Nicobar islands. With the heat on the army in Delhi, the chief—noted for his own personal integrity—could use the cooler climes of Bhutan where he embarked on his first foreign visit to also think about a new damage control strategy. *by Sandeep Unnithan*



Mamata Banerjee may run her affairs as she wishes, but her 95 councillors will have 76 experts to seek advice from. The list includes sportsmen, businessmen, actors, painters—people who supported her fight against the Left.

DELHI | The Karat Skid

Prakash Karat is in the firing line. After running the party and dictating its policies for long, the CPI(M) boss is suddenly at the receiving end of flak from his own comrades. There is increasing anger about his political agenda—popularly known as the Karat Line—which went against the directions of the party congress in Coimbatore and led the CPI(M) into complete isolation. With the party losing ground in West Bengal, Karat is even being criticised for withdrawing support to the UPA Government. Now some sections of the CPI(M) are calling for a re-entry into the UPA fold. The party is being pushed into invoking the 'extended CC' clause of its constitution—unprecedented in its history—to assess the West



Bengal failure. With the West Bengal unit and many Politburo members questioning his ability to take the party forward, Karat is expecting Pinaray Vijayan's Kerala unit to lower lifeboats for him during the extended Central Committee (CC) meeting. *by Shafi Rahman*

HYDERABAD | Royal Blunder

His Majesty would not have been amused. The Andhra Pradesh Government has been forced to restrict the 500th anniversary celebrations of Sri Krishna-devaraya to be held from July 5 to August 8. The reasons: more than just a cash crunch, the hiccups around the celebrations were victim to a sloppy reading of history textbooks by the state's bureaucrats. The official celebrations committee discovered at its second meeting last week that the historic coronation took place in Hampi on August 8, 1509. Therefore, the 500th year began on August 9, 2008 and concluded on August 7, 2009. In effect, year-long festivities that were being planned should be long over. No one has been held accountable. Now the state Government can justify cutting back on the celebration expenses from Rs 5 crore to Rs 1 crore and shelving the plan to build a Rs 10-crore Krishnadevaraya museum. A public private partnership could now step in to take over the celebratory reins. Hopefully its fact checking will be more accurate.

by Anurag K. Menon